

Chapter 3

Instructors Manual

This chapter covers:

- The social power of myths and the myth of the non-accent
- A discussion of the definition of *accent*, *dialect*, and *language*
- The difference between L1 and L2 accents
- The analogy of the Sound House to explain the development of an L1 and L2 accent and explain the difficulty involved in trying to eliminate one accent in favor of another

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. *What does the idea of style shifting do to the Sound House analogy? Many people are bilingual or multilingual, and for each language they also have multiple styles. Is there a way to adapt the metaphor to account for this, or does it simply break down?*

Sample Answer: I think the analogy holds for multilingualism and style shifting, with perhaps a little tweaking. A native speaker of several languages will just have multiple wings to their Sound Houses (or perhaps Sound Mansions) with a different architectural style for each language they speak. Within every speaker's Sound House, each room is designed for a specific style. These rooms might be redecorated as the speaker develops his or her linguistic identity, and rooms can be remodeled as the speaker learns to speak in different styles throughout his or her life. Speakers can add walls within larger rooms to create smaller rooms to correspond to new styles as needed. In this scenario the sound house doesn't change its basic structure, but it can be used for a changing range of functions.

2. *How many prominent people (politicians, actors, policy makers, educators, media personalities, etc.) can you think of who speak English with an L2 accent? What impact does a foreign accent seem to have on the individual's life?*

Sample Answer: I can think of several prominent people with L2 accents: Benicio del Toro, Penelope Cruz, Antonio Banderas, Javier Bardem, Arnold Schwarzenegger, Jackie Chan, Chow Yun Fat, and Marion Cotillard. These people are primarily actors, and I would imagine their L2 accents may restrict their roles in American movies, but their accents do not diminish their success or the amount of respect they receive as actors. Arnold Schwarzenegger's accent does not appear to have had much of a negative impact on his acting or political career since he was a highly successful actor and won the governorship of California in 2004. However, I do wonder if the general acceptance of his accent was due at least in part to the fact that he is from a European country (rather than an Asian, African, or South American country).

3. Interview some friends or family – a group of three or four people /– and try to elicit how they feel about different varieties of English and different L2 accents. Take notes. On what do they agree? Where do they differ? (One might find accent x “friendly” while the other one finds it “unsophisticated,” for example.) Can you account for the differences, or lack of differences? What surprised you?

Sample Answer: My participants were four white females from California. All of them are 21 years old. They agreed on most of their evaluations of the different varieties of English and L2 accents that we discussed. All of the four friends I interviewed made a distinction between “charming Southern accents,” which they imagine are those used by the elite on luxurious estates, and “horrible Southern accents,” which they imagine are used by the uneducated poor living in the backwoods. I was surprised at how negatively my friends reacted to a dialect they associated with the working class, even though two of them come from working class backgrounds themselves.

They also agreed on their evaluation of certain European and Asian accents. All of my friends thought that French, Spanish, and Italian accents were very attractive, whereas they reacted negatively to Chinese, Japanese, and Korean accents and thought they were difficult to understand. While this was an unfair judgment, it did not surprise me because I think that many white Americans consider certain European accents to be “good” accents and think many other L2 accents are “bad” accents.

The one area where my participants disagreed was regarding the New York accent. Two of my friends thought the accent sounded “rough,” “dangerous,” or “cynical” and reported that they did not like the accent. However, the other two thought the accent sounded “sophisticated” and “street-smart.” This difference can be explained because the two who liked the accent are actors who plan to move to New York after graduation to pursue a career in musical theater. For them, this variety of English is connected to a cosmopolitan center for theater and arts and carries prestige. The two participants who did not like the accent are from small cities and dislike major urban centers. For them, a dialect closely associated with a major urban center is associated with crowds, danger, and dirty city streets, which is why they don’t like the accent.

4. What accents do you personally dislike or find irritating? Describe a situation in which you reacted this way to a variety of English other than your own. After reading this far, do you have any insight into your own reactions?

Sample Answer: Before taking this class, I thought some southern accents were really annoying. For me, some southern accents brought up images of rural, uneducated, ignorant, poor people. However, now I understand that my negative feelings for that language variety are really my negative feelings for the people who speak that language variety. I come from a rural, working-class area and since the southern accents that bothered me are associated with the rural poor, I think my disdain for those dialects was rooted in my desire to disassociate myself with the kind of rural, working-class life that I am trying to escape. However, now that I am learning about language ideologies in this class, I am working on breaking my prejudice against those accents.

5. *Think about this statement: Discrimination does not justify discrimination. How this might relate to the topic at hand?*

Sample Answer: To me, this statement means that just because language varieties are different (as in we can discriminate *between* them) does not mean that some language varieties should be considered any better or worse than others (as in we should not discriminate *against* any of them).

6. *Do an internet search for “accent reduction” and “lose your accent.” What kind of articles and advertisements come up? What credentials do the people offering these courses have? Do you see any patterns?*

Sample Answer: A Google search for “accent reduction” and “lose your accent” brought up 500,000 and over 6 million hits, respectively. The hits on the first page of each search were primarily for paid accent reduction classes. Many of these accent reduction courses mentioned the qualifications of the company founder, who was typically a linguist, speech pathologist, or ESL teacher. However, the qualifications of other trainers working at the company were rarely mentioned, and some sites offered no specific information about the qualifications of any company employee (although they may say something vague to the effect that they have “qualified trainers”).

From the website

Audio

1. *Listen to the clips of speakers from Maine, New Orleans, Appalachia, and Utah as well as the clips of Native American, African American, and Jewish speakers. Do you think you could have identified where the first speakers are from? Could you have identified the second speakers’ ethnicities? If so, what features do you think indicate geographical region or ethnicity? If not, why not? Is it a simple matter to identify a speaker’s geographical region or ethnicity from voice alone?*

Sample Answer: I would not be able to be very specific in identifying the geographic location of each of the speakers from Maine, New Orleans, Appalachia, or Utah. I would have been unable to identify the Maine dialect since I have not been exposed to it before. I would have identified the speakers from New Orleans and Appalachia as using Southern dialects and I would have identified the speakers from Utah as using a dialect of the West, but I wouldn’t have been able to confidently choose a state for each speaker.

In terms of distinguishing a person’s ethnicity based on his or her voice, I think there is no way to tell for sure what ethnicity a person is from his or her voice alone because pronunciation is based on social groupings rather than genetic makeup. So, for example, some African Americans may speak a variety of English associated with African Americans, but some will not. Some people of other races will also speak in a dialect associated with African Americans. In terms of identifying these samples as being associated with a certain ethnic group, I don’t think I would

be able to identify some of these speakers without knowing their ethnic background ahead of time. For example, the speaker in Alaska 1 “sounds Native American” to me, perhaps because of her pace of speech and her intonation pattern, but I think I am just listening for anything that would reinforce the idea that she was Native American since the website tells me her ethnicity. If I didn’t know anything about her ethnic background before listening to the clip, I might not be able to tell. For some of the speakers, I still can’t identify any features corresponding to an ethnic group even when I know the speaker’s ethnicity. For example, I wasn’t able to identify any features that marked the Native American speaker in New Mexico 2 as part of any particular ethnic group.

2. Listen to a selection of the clips that demonstrate the language varieties mentioned in this chapter and revisit the definitions of language, dialect and accent discussed on pages 44–46. Can all of these language varieties be considered dialects or are some just slang or bad English? Consider this question from page 46:

Why do people call the variety of English that many African Americans speak Black slang (or a Black accent or African American English) but call Cockney and Gullah dialects?

Sample Answer: Yes, all of the accents listed in the book and sampled on the website are definitely dialects of English. Each variety, while different from the next, is systematic, rule-governed, and completely expressive – these accents do not represent a sloppy rendition of Standard American English, but rather are unique and fully formed systems of English. In regards to the question from the textbook, I think some people consider the variety of English spoken by many African Americans to be slang instead of a dialect because of prejudice. Some people consider African American English to be less valid than other varieties of English, so they don’t legitimize it by labeling it as a dialect on par with Southern English, California English, British English, etc. But African American English is a legitimate dialect, not slang.

3. Listen to a selection of the clips that demonstrate the language varieties mentioned in this chapter. What do you think about these accents being used by famous figures or news anchors? Would any of these accents impede a person’s career in politics or broadcast media in your area? Why or why not?

Sample Answer: I think it would be perfectly fine for famous figures and news anchors to use any of these accents. Certainly none of these accents would impede a person’s ability to be an able politician or news anchor, although the reception of some accents might be rather lukewarm until those people with linguistic prejudices realized that a prominent person’s accent had no impact on his or her effectiveness.

Video

On the rise: Accent reduction classes
ABC News on Campus

<http://abcnews.go.com/US/video/rise-accent-reduction-classes-10521083>

This video provides material for discussion of expectations surrounding L1 and L2 accents in the workplace and accent reduction courses.

1. *What assumptions underlie this story regarding accents in the workplace and the effectiveness of accent reduction courses?*

Sample Answer: This story has several underlying assumptions about accents in the workplace and the effectiveness of accent reduction courses. First of all, a major underlying assumption is that an employee's L1 or L2 accent should be as minimal as possible and that it is appropriate for an employer to ask an excellent employee to take accent reduction classes. This assumption is connected to the assumption that accent reduction classes are helpful and that accents can be changed with effort (and money). The story states that accent reduction clients spend only one hour each week for two to three months meeting with their accent reduction specialist, and in that time "half of [one's] accent could disappear" (although it is unclear how that would be measured). In addition, there are standard language ideologies underlying this piece – the reporter explicitly states that there is a "correct" pronunciation of English and that deviations from this "correct" pronunciation are "mistakes." In focusing on one worker's strategy to switch between his native South African accent and a more Americanized accent and stating that it is a difficult but possible task to maintain two accents (one at home and one in the workplace), the reporter implies that the difficulty lies in maintaining two accents, not replacing one with another. By both stating and implying that accent reduction classes are effective, the story assumes that accents can be changed without overwhelming difficulty, which perhaps legitimizes an employer's and customer's lack of effort in understanding unfamiliar L1 and L2 accents.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Discuss the myth of the non-accent and how the perception of an accent is a matter of perspective. Play a few clips of the dialects samples provided on the website that accompanies this book. Choose clips from different regions of the country or the world, and after each clip, have students discuss how their own accents would be described by speakers of that dialect.
2. Have the students think about the L2 accents they have in any other languages they speak. What sounds in their L2s do they have trouble with? Have they ever had a communication breakdown that was attributed to their L2 accents? If so, do they think the communication breakdown was entirely their own fault?
3. Revisit the case of James Kahakua and pose these questions from page 52 to your students:

*If *SAE is something logically and reasonably required of broadcast news reporters, why was it required of James Kahakua, and not of Peter Jennings (Canada) or Dan Rathers (Texas)?*

And, a more difficult question: what is right or wrong about asking Mr. Kahakua to pretend? If he is capable of faking an accent, why shouldn't his employer ask him to do this, for those few minutes he is reading the weather on the radio?

Encourage the students to explore the motivations and expectations of James Kahakua, the radio station, and the listeners in light of what they have learned about accent and language ideology in this course.

4. Ask students to listen to local, national, and international news programs over the course of a week, examining the language varieties used by the news anchors. Do all the anchors speak a variety that aligns with the students' ideas of *SAE? Are there any anchors that speak with any discernible L2 or nonstandard L1 accent? If so, how do their L1 or L2 accents affect their job performance?

5. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.